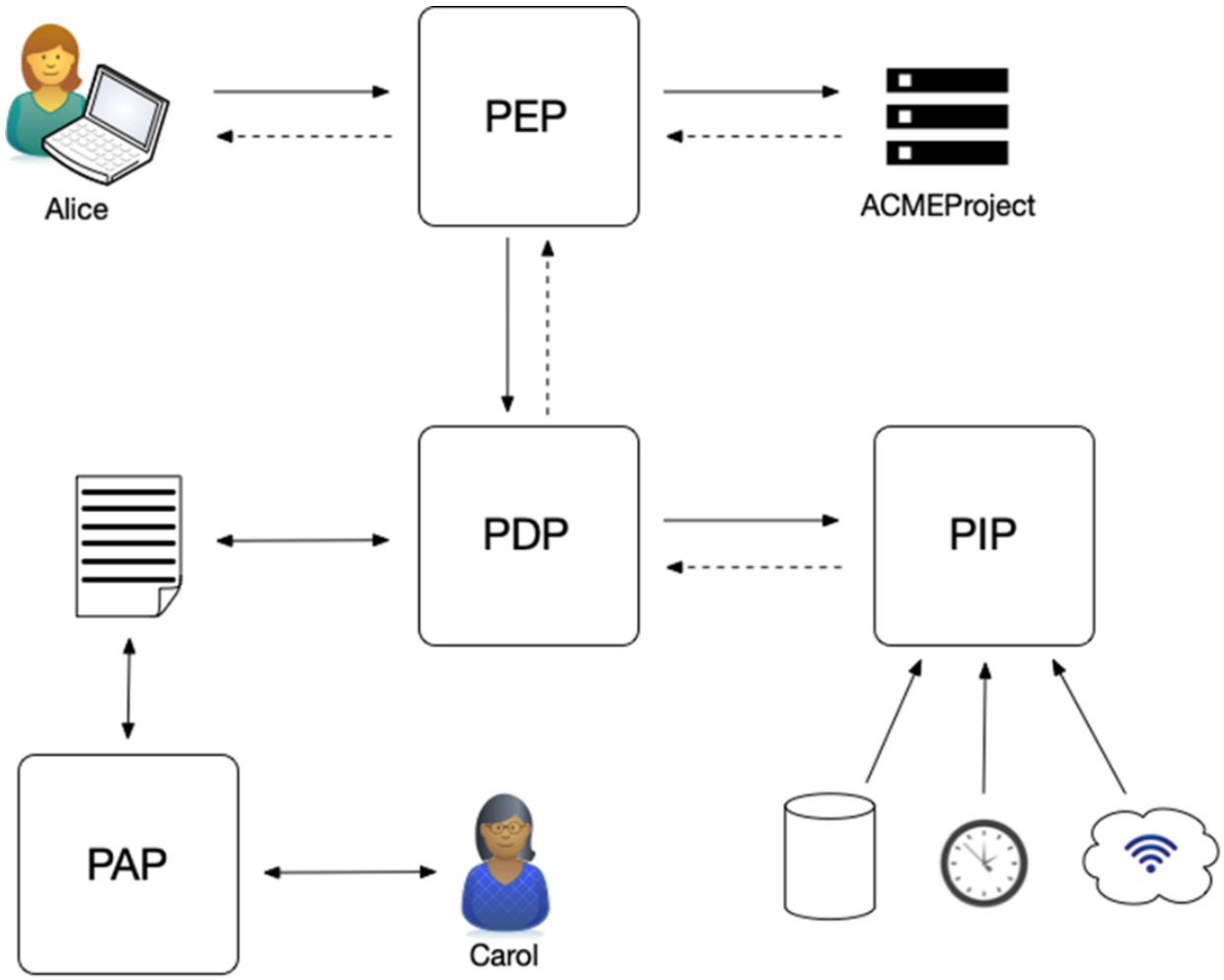


Figure 4.2 Authorization reference architecture showing how access decisions are made. The Policy Enforcement Point (PEP) intercepts Alice's request to ACMEProject and sends it to the Policy Decision Point (PDP). The PDP evaluates the request using policies from the Policy Administration Point (PAP), managed by Carol, and retrieves context from the Policy Information Point (PIP), which sources attributes from systems like identity providers, time servers, and network telemetry. The PDP returns a decision, which the PEP enforces in real time.

In this section, we will explore how this reference architecture works, why it matters, and how it relates to both legacy systems and today's cloud-native applications.

4.4.1 How access decisions are made

Let's say Alice is a project manager at ACME Corp. One evening, she logs into ACMEProject, the company's internal dashboard for project tracking and reporting, as shown in figure 4.2. Managers like Alice use ACMEProject